塞翁失马

谁知道是福还是祸

Old Sai Loses His Horse

Who Can Say What Is Luck?

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 陈浩然[†]二十四岁，研究生刚毕业。他一向相信，只要努力，就一定会有好结果。可是这一年秋天，一封邮件让他第一次开始怀疑这句话。他也没有想到，帮他想明白这件事的，居然是爷爷讲的一个两千多年前的老故事。

没有得到的工作

2 浩然[‡]最想去的，是上海[§]一家很有名的互联网公司。为了这份工作，他准备了整整半年：简历改了十几次，练习题做了几十道，还专门去上海参加了三轮面试。最后一轮面试结束的时候，经理笑着跟他握手，说："欢迎你下个月来上班。"浩然马上给爸爸妈妈打电话，又在朋友圈[¶]里发了一张公司大楼的照片。同学们纷纷给他发消息，祝贺他找到了好工作。

† 陈浩然 *Chén Hàorán* Chen Haoran
‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran
§ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
¶ 朋友圈 *péngyouquān* WeChat Moments

Chen Haoran was twenty-four and had just finished his master's degree. He had always believed that as long as you worked hard, things would turn out well. But that autumn, an email made him doubt it for the first time. Nor did he expect that what would help him make sense of it was, of all things, a story more than two thousand years old, told by his grandfather. 1

The Job He Didn't Get

The place Haoran most wanted to work was a well-known internet company in Shanghai. He spent a whole six months preparing for this job: he rewrote his CV a dozen times, worked through dozens of practice problems, and even made special trips to Shanghai for three rounds of interviews. When the last interview ended, the manager shook his hand with a smile and said, "We look forward to seeing you at work next month." Haoran rang his parents straight away and posted a photo of the company's building on WeChat Moments. One after another, his classmates sent him messages congratulating him on landing a good job. 2

3 可是两个星期以后，他收到了一封邮件。邮件很短：“很遗憾[†]地通知您，由于公司业务调整，这个职位暂时取消。”浩然[‡]把邮件看了三遍，还是不敢相信。他给经理打电话，经理很客气：“不是你不够好，而是我们整个部门今年都不要人了。我也没办法。”

4 那天晚上，浩然一个人在房间里坐了很久。他想不明白，究竟是哪里出了问题。难道这半年的努力都白费了吗？更让他生气的是，这一天好像什么都不顺利：下午出门忘了带伞，全身都被大雨打湿了；晚上手机又掉在地上，摔坏了。他拿着黑了的手机自言自语[§]：“真是祸不单行[¶]。”

5 妈妈打电话来，让他先回老家住一段时间：“大城市的工作未必就是最好的。你爷爷一个人在家，你正好陪陪他。”浩然觉得回老家就像承认自己失败了，

† 遗憾 *yíhàn* regrettably

‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

§ 自言自语 *zìyán zìyǔ* to talk to oneself

¶ 祸不单行 *huò bù dān xíng* “misfortunes never come singly”

But two weeks later he received an email. It was short: "We regret to inform you that, owing to a restructuring of the company's business, this position has been cancelled for the time being." Haoran read the email three times and still couldn't believe it. He phoned the manager, who was very polite: "It's not that you aren't good enough; it's that our whole department isn't hiring anyone this year. There's nothing I can do." 3

That evening Haoran sat alone in his room for a long time. He couldn't work out where exactly things had gone wrong. Had all those months of hard work really been for nothing? What made him even angrier was that nothing seemed to go right that day: he went out in the afternoon without an umbrella and got soaked to the skin by the rain; then in the evening he dropped his phone on the floor and broke it. Holding the dead phone, he muttered to himself, "It never rains but it pours." 4

His mother called and told him to come back to his hometown for a while: "A job in a big city isn't necessarily the best thing. Your grandfather is on his own at home, so you can keep him company." To Haoran, going home felt like admitting he had failed, 5

5 可是他实在不知道还能去哪儿，只好买了一张回家的火车票。

爷爷的故事

6 爷爷住在北方一个小城里，家里有一个小院子。他退休以前是中学语文老师，教了三十多年书，最喜欢给人讲故事。浩然†到家的时候，爷爷正在院子里给花换盆。看见孙子提着箱子，低着头走进来，爷爷什么也没问，只是给他倒了一杯热茶。

7 吃完晚饭，浩然终于忍不住，把工作的事都说了出来。他越说越生气："爷爷，您说我是不是运气太差了？别人都找到了工作，就我一个人……"爷爷听完，不但没有安慰他，反而笑了起来。浩然有点儿不高兴："您笑什么？"

† 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

but he really didn't know where else to go, so he had no choice but to buy a train ticket home. 5

Grandfather's Story

Grandfather lived in a small town in the north, in a house with a little courtyard. Before he retired he had taught Chinese at a middle school for more than thirty years, and there was nothing he liked better than telling stories. When Haoran got home, Grandfather was in the courtyard repotting his flowers. Seeing his grandson walk in with his suitcase and his head hanging, Grandfather asked nothing; he just poured him a cup of hot tea. 6

After dinner Haoran finally couldn't hold it in any longer and told him all about the job. The more he talked, the angrier he got: "Grandpa, don't you think I just have terrible luck? Everyone else has found a job, and I'm the only one who..." When Grandfather had heard him out, instead of comforting him, he started to laugh. Haoran was a little annoyed. "What are you laughing at?" 7

8 “我笑你啊，跟两千多年前那些邻居一样。”爷爷放下茶杯，“你听说过‘塞翁失马’[1]吗？”“当然听说过。‘塞翁失马，焉知非福’[2]，小学就学过了。别人遇到坏事[3]的时候，就用这句话安慰他。”“你知道的不是故事，而是一句话。”爷爷摇了摇头，“一句话很容易说，可是故事里的事，没有那么简单。今天晚上我给你完整地讲一遍吧。”

9 爷爷告诉他，这个故事最早写在一本叫《淮南子》[4]的书里。两千多年前的西汉[5]，淮南王[6]刘安[7]和他身边的一些读书人一起编了这本书，里面讲了很多关于自然和人生的道理。“很多人以为‘塞翁’[8]是一个姓塞[9]的老人，”爷爷说，

1 塞翁失马 *Sàiwēng shī mǎ* “the old man of the frontier loses his horse”
2 焉知非福 *yān zhī fēi fú* “how do you know it isn’t a blessing?”
3 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune
4 淮南子 *Huáinánzǐ* Huainanzi, Western Han book of thought
5 西汉 *Xī Hàn* Western Han dynasty (206 BC–AD 9)
6 淮南王 *Huáinán Wáng* King of Huainan
7 刘安 *Liú Ān* Liu An (179–122 BC)
8 塞翁 *Sàiwēng* the old man of the frontier
9 塞 *Sài* Sai (as a surname)

"I'm laughing at you. You're just like those neighbours two thousand years ago." Grandfather put down his cup. "Have you heard of 'the old man of the frontier loses his horse'?" "Of course. 'The old man of the frontier loses his horse — who knows if it isn't a blessing?' We learned that in primary school. When something bad happens to someone, you comfort them with it." "What you know isn't the story; it's a saying." Grandfather shook his head. "A saying is easy to say, but what happens in the story isn't that simple. Tonight I'll tell you the whole thing." 8

Grandfather told him that the story was first written down in a book called the Huainanzi. More than two thousand years ago, in the Western Han, Liu An, the King of Huainan, compiled it together with scholars around him, and it is full of ideas about nature and human life. "Many people think 'Sai Weng' was an old man whose surname was Sai," Grandfather said, 9

“其实‘塞†’不是他的姓，而是边塞‡的意思，就是北边靠近边境的地方。‘翁§’就是老人。书上连他叫什么名字都没写。”浩然¶有点儿意外：“我一直以为他姓塞*呢。”

马跑了

“那时候，在北方的边塞，住着一位老人。”爷爷慢慢地讲了起来，“据说他很懂得看事情，比别人想得远。他家里养着几匹马。在边塞，马是非常重要的，可以拉车，可以种地，也可以骑着去很远的地方。有一天，他家的一匹马不知道为什么，自己跑了，一直跑过了边境，跑到了胡人#住的地方。”

“胡人是谁？”浩然问。

† 塞 *sài* frontier pass, border post
‡ 边塞 *biānsài* frontier fortress region
§ 翁 *wēng* old man
¶ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran
* 塞 *Sài* Sai (as a surname)
胡人 *Húrén* the Hu, northern peoples

"but in fact 'sai' isn't his surname. It means the frontier — the land up north near the border. 'Weng' just means old man. The book doesn't even give his name." Haoran was a little surprised. "I always thought his surname was Sai." 9

The Horse Runs Away

"In those days, on the northern frontier, there lived an old man," Grandfather began slowly. "They say he had a gift for reading events and could see further ahead than other people. His family kept a few horses. On the frontier, horses mattered a great deal: they could pull carts, work the fields, and carry you a long way. One day, for no reason anyone knew, one of his horses ran off on its own, right across the border into the lands where the Hu people lived." 10

"Who were the Hu?" asked Haoran. 11

11 “古时候，中原[†]的人把北方和西方的一些民族叫做胡人[‡]。他们很会养马，也很会骑马。马跑到了那边，就像石头掉进了大海，很难再找回来了。”

12 “邻居们听说了，都到老人家里来安慰他：‘真可惜啊，那么好的一匹马，说没就没了。’大家都以为老人会很难过，可是老人反而一点儿也不着急，他平静地说：‘这难道就不会是一件好事吗？’邻居们都很奇怪。马丢了，怎么会是好事呢？有人觉得他心里难过，故意这么说；也有人觉得他年纪大了，想事情已经不清楚了。大家走的时候都在想：这个老人究竟在想什么？”

13 浩然[§]忍不住说：“这个老人是不是太想得开了？要是我，肯定难过好几天。”“难过是正常的。”爷爷说，“我觉得他心里也未必不难过。他不是不心疼那匹马，而是不愿意太早下结论。

† 中原 *Zhōngyuán* the Central Plains
‡ 胡人 *Húrén* the Hu, northern peoples
§ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

"In ancient times, people of the Central Plains used 'Hu' for various peoples to the north and west. They were very good at raising and riding horses. A horse that ran off over there was like a stone dropped into the sea: almost impossible to get back." 11

"When the neighbours heard, they all came round to comfort the old man: 'What a shame — such a fine horse, gone just like that.' Everyone expected him to be upset, but instead he wasn't worried in the least. He said calmly, 'Who's to say this won't turn out to be a good thing?' The neighbours were puzzled. The horse was lost — how could that be good? Some thought he was hurting inside and only said it on purpose; others thought he was getting old and no longer thinking clearly. As they left, they were all wondering: what on earth was the old man thinking?" 12

Haoran couldn't help saying, "Wasn't the old man taking it a bit too lightly? If it were me, I'd be upset for days." "Being upset is normal," said Grandfather. "I don't think he was necessarily untroubled inside, either. It wasn't that he didn't care about the horse; it was that he didn't want to judge too soon. 13

13 马跑了，这是一件事；这件事以后会带来什么，谁知道呢？”

马回来了

14 “过了几个月，有一天，邻居们忽然听见远处传来马叫的声音。大家跑出去一看，居然是老人那匹马回来了！更让人吃惊的是，它后面还跟着一匹胡人[†]的马，又高又大，跑得飞快，一看就是难得的好马。”

15 “这下好了吧？”浩然[‡]笑着说。“邻居们也是这么想的。”爷爷说，“他们又来到老人家里，这一次是来祝贺的：‘丢了一匹马，反而多了一匹好马，您的运气真好啊！’可是老人脸上并没有高兴的样子。他说：‘这难道就不会是一件坏事[§]吗？’

† 胡人 *Húrén* the Hu, northern peoples

‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

§ 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune

The horse running away is one thing. What it will lead to later — who can say?" 13

The Horse Comes Back

"A few months later, the neighbours suddenly heard horses neighing in the distance. They ran out to look, and to their amazement it was the old man's horse, come home! Even more astonishing, behind it came a horse from the Hu lands — tall and big, swift as the wind; you could tell at a glance it was a rare and splendid animal." 14

"Well, that's good news, then?" Haoran said with a grin. "That's what the neighbours thought too," said Grandfather. "They came to the old man's house again, and this time it was to congratulate him: 'You lost one horse and ended up with a better one — what luck!' But the old man didn't look pleased at all. He said, 'Who's to say this won't turn out to be a bad thing?' 15

15 邻居们又不明白了。多了一匹好马，怎么会是坏事[†]呢？”

16 “老人有一个儿子，最喜欢骑马。家里有了那匹好马以后，他每天都骑着它出去跑。可是那匹马的脾气很大，还没有被训练好。有一天，儿子从马上摔了下来，把大腿的骨头摔断了。从那以后，他走路就一直不方便。”

17 “邻居们又来安慰老人：‘真是太不幸了！好马带来的原来是灾难啊。’可是老人还是平静地说：‘这难道就不会是一件好事吗？’”浩然[‡]听得有点儿着急了：“腿都断了，还能是好事？”爷爷喝了一口茶：“别急，故事还没完。”

† 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune

‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

Once again the neighbours were baffled. How could gaining a fine horse be bad?" 15

"The old man had a son who loved riding more than anything. Once the family had that fine horse, he rode it out every day. But the horse had a fierce temper and hadn't been properly broken in. One day the son was thrown from the horse and broke his thigh bone. From then on, he always walked with difficulty." 16

"The neighbours came to comfort the old man yet again: 'How terrible! So that fine horse brought nothing but disaster.' But the old man still said calmly, 'Who's to say this won't turn out to be a good thing?'" Haoran was getting impatient. "His leg was broken — how could that be good?" Grandfather took a sip of tea. "Patience. The story isn't over." 17

后来呢

18 “又过了一年，胡人[1]的大军打了过来。边塞[2]附近的年轻男人都拿起了武器去打仗[3]。书上说，边塞附近的人，十个里面死了九个。可是老人的儿子因为腿不好，不用去打仗，就这样活了下来。父亲和儿子两个人都平平安安的。”爷爷讲完，院子里安静了很久。

19 “这就是‘因祸得福[4]’吧？”浩然[5]小声说。“可以这么说。”爷爷点了点头，“可是你想想，儿子的腿一辈子都不方便，那么多邻居家的儿子再也没有回来。对老人来说，这是福；对整个边塞来说，这是一场灾难。”“那这个故事究竟想说什么呢？”“福和祸[6]常常连在一起，还会互相变化。今天的好事，明天未必还是好事；今天的坏事[7]，以后也未必一直是坏事。

1 胡人 *Húrén* the Hu, northern peoples
2 边塞 *biānsài* frontier fortress region
3 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to go to war
4 因祸得福 *yīn huò dé fú* “to profit from misfortune”
5 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran
6 祸 *huò* misfortune
7 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune

And Then?

"Another year went by, and a great Hu army came over the border. All the young men near the frontier took up arms and went to fight. The book says that of the people near the frontier, nine in ten died. But because of his bad leg, the old man's son didn't have to go to war, and so he survived. Father and son both came through safe and sound." When Grandfather finished, the courtyard was quiet for a long time. 18

"So that's 'a blessing in disguise'?" Haoran said quietly. "You could say so," Grandfather nodded. "But think about it: the son was lame for the rest of his life, and so many of the neighbours' sons never came home. For the old man it was good fortune; for the frontier as a whole it was a catastrophe." "Then what is the story really trying to say?" "Good and bad fortune are often bound up together, and they can turn into each other. Today's good thing may not still be good tomorrow; today's bad thing won't necessarily stay bad forever. 19

人看得到眼前，却看不到很远的地方。”

那天晚上，浩然[†]很久都没有睡着。他又想起了经理在电话里说的那句话：“我也没办法。”故事并没有让他马上开心起来，他还是很失望。可是有一个想法慢慢变了：现在就说这是“坏运气”，也许还太早了。

接下来的几个月，浩然留在了老家。一个高中同学在城里开了一家小公司，帮当地的农民在网上卖水果，正缺一个会做软件的人。工资只有上海[‡]的一半，办公室里也只有七八个人。浩然本来觉得这份工作配不上自己，可是他想，先做着看吧。

没想到，在小公司里，他学到的东西居然比想象的多得多。在大公司，他可能只负责一个很小的部分；在这里，从做网站到跟农民聊天，什么都要自己来。

† 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

‡ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

We can see what's right in front of us, but not what lies far ahead." 19

That night Haoran lay awake for a long time. He thought again of what the manager had said on the phone: "There's nothing I can do." The story hadn't cheered him up straight away; he was still deeply disappointed. But one idea was slowly shifting: to call this "bad luck" now might be too soon. 20

For the next few months, Haoran stayed in his hometown. A high-school classmate had started a small company in town, helping local farmers sell fruit online, and he badly needed someone who could build software. The pay was only half of what Shanghai had offered, and there were only seven or eight people in the office. At first Haoran felt the job was beneath him, but he thought he might as well give it a try. 21

To his surprise, he learned far more at the small company than he had imagined. At a big company he might have been in charge of one tiny piece; here he had to do everything himself, from building the website to chatting with the farmers. 22

22 有一次，他跟着一位果农在山上走了一整天，晚上回来腿都疼了，心里却有一种以前没有过的满足。

23 十二月的一个晚上，大学同学周凯[†]给他打来电话。周凯去年进了那家公司的别的部门，浩然[‡]一直觉得他的运气比自己好。电话里，他的声音很低："浩然，我失业了。公司今年业务不好，我们部门的人走了一大半。"浩然一下子不知道说什么好。谁知道，进了大公司的人，反而先丢了工作呢？他本来想说"塞翁失马[§]，焉知非福[¶]"，话到了嘴边，却没有说出口。他只是安静地听周凯说了一个多小时，最后说："过年回来，我请你吃饭。"

24 挂了电话，他心里很乱。

† 周凯 *Zhōu Kǎi* Zhou Kai

‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

§ 塞翁失马 *Sàiwēng shī mǎ* "the old man of the frontier loses his horse"

¶ 焉知非福 *yān zhī fēi fú* "how do you know it isn't a blessing?"

Once he spent a whole day walking the hills with a fruit grower; he came back that evening with aching legs, but with a kind of satisfaction he had never felt before. 22

One evening in December, his university classmate Zhou Kai phoned him. Zhou Kai had joined a different department of that same company the year before, and Haoran had always thought he was luckier than himself. On the phone his voice was low: "Haoran, I've lost my job. The company's had a bad year, and more than half our department is gone." For a moment Haoran didn't know what to say. Who would have guessed that the one who got into the big company would be the first to lose his job? He was about to say, "The old man lost his horse — who knows if it isn't a blessing?", but though the words were on the tip of his tongue, he didn't say them. He just listened quietly to Zhou Kai for over an hour, and at the end said, "Come home for New Year, and dinner's on me." 23

After he hung up, his feelings were all in a tangle. 24

他有一点儿轻松，好像自己躲过了一件坏事[†]；可是马上又觉得很不好意思，因为朋友正在难过。他想起了爷爷的故事：老人的儿子活了下来，可是邻居们的儿子没有回来。他这才明白，那句老话不能随便拿来安慰别人，别人的不幸，更不能看成自己的运气。

祸福[‡]

冬天快过去的时候，爷爷在院子里扫雪，不小心摔倒了。浩然[§]听见声音跑出来，马上把爷爷送到了医院。还好，只是脚受了伤，休息几个月就能好。妈妈在电话里说："还好你在家。要是你在上海[¶]，我们真不知道怎么办。"

爷爷躺在床上，不但不抱怨，反而开起了玩笑：

† 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune
‡ 祸福 *huòfú* misfortune and fortune
§ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran
¶ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

He felt a little relieved, as if he had dodged something bad; but at once he felt ashamed, because his friend was hurting. He remembered Grandfather's story: the old man's son survived, but the neighbours' sons never came back. Only now did he understand that the old saying couldn't be used lightly to comfort people, and that someone else's misfortune should never be counted as your own good luck. 24

Fortune and Misfortune

As winter was drawing to an end, Grandfather slipped and fell while sweeping snow in the courtyard. Haoran heard the noise, ran out, and took him straight to the hospital. Luckily he had only hurt his foot, and a few months' rest would see him right. His mother said on the phone, "Thank goodness you were home. If you'd been in Shanghai, I really don't know what we'd have done." 25

Lying in bed, Grandfather didn't complain; instead he started joking: 26

26 “你看，我也成了塞翁[†]的儿子了。摔了一下，就有孙子天天陪着，这不也是因祸得福[‡]吗？”浩然[§]听了也笑了。可是看着爷爷的脚，他心里清楚，即使是因祸得福，疼也是真的疼。福和祸[¶]，从来都不是分得那么清楚的。

27 三月的一天，浩然又收到了一封邮件，是上海[*]那家公司发来的。公司成立了一个新部门，需要人，问他还愿意不愿意去，工资比去年说的还高一些。半年前，他做梦都想收到这样一封邮件。可是现在，他看着手机，却犹豫了。

28 小公司刚接了一个大项目，同学希望他留下来；爷爷的脚还没有完全好；可是上海的机会，这次不去，恐怕就不会再有了。他问爷爷：“您说，我究竟该不该去？哪一个是福，哪一个是祸？”爷爷想了想，说：“这个问题，塞翁也回答不了。即使是他，也不知道明天会发生什么。

† 塞翁 *Sàiwēng* the old man of the frontier
‡ 因祸得福 *yīn huò dé fú* “to profit from misfortune”
§ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran
¶ 祸 *huò* misfortune
* 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

"Look, now I'm the old frontiersman's son. One fall, and I get my grandson 26
by my side every day — isn't that a blessing in disguise too?" Haoran laughed too. But looking at Grandfather's foot, he knew perfectly well that even if it was a blessing in disguise, the pain was still real pain. Good fortune and bad were never so easy to tell apart.

One day in March, Haoran received another email. It was from the company 27
in Shanghai. The company had set up a new department and needed people. Was he still willing to come? The pay was even a little higher than last year's offer. Six months earlier he would have given anything to receive an email like this. But now, looking at his phone, he hesitated.

The small company had just landed a big project, and his classmate wanted 28
him to stay; Grandfather's foot hadn't fully healed; and yet if he passed up the Shanghai chance this time, it would probably never come again. He asked Grandfather, "What do you think — should I go or not? Which one is the good fortune, and which the bad?" Grandfather thought for a moment. "That's a question even the old man of the frontier couldn't answer. Even he didn't know what tomorrow would bring.

他厉害的地方，不是知道结果，而是不着急给事情下结论。去上海[†]未必就好，留下来也不一定就不好。”

那天晚上，浩然[‡]一个人在院子里坐了很久。天上的星星很亮，远处传来几声狗叫。他想起半年前那个下雨的晚上，自己拿着摔坏的手机说“祸不单行[§]”。那时候他以为，那是他最糟糕的一天。现在回头看，那一天带来的，好像不全是坏事[¶]，也不全是好事，只是让他的生活变得不一样了。

他还没有决定要不要去上海。可是这一次，他不再那么害怕做错选择了。回到屋里，爷爷还没睡，正戴着眼镜看书。爷爷抬起头问：“想好了吗？”浩然笑了笑：“还没有。不过不管选哪条路，以后会怎么样，谁知道呢？”爷爷也笑了。

† 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

‡ 浩然 *Hàorán* Haoran

§ 祸不单行 *huò bù dān xíng* “misfortunes never come singly”

¶ 坏事 *huàishì* bad thing, misfortune

What was remarkable about him wasn't that he knew how things would end, but that he was in no hurry to pass judgement. Going to Shanghai isn't necessarily good, and staying isn't necessarily bad." 28

That night Haoran sat alone in the courtyard for a long time. The stars were bright, and a few dogs barked in the distance. He remembered that rainy night six months before, when he had held his broken phone and said, "It never rains but it pours." Back then he had thought it was the worst day of his life. Looking back now, what that day had brought him seemed neither all bad nor all good. It had simply made his life different. 29

He still hadn't decided whether to go to Shanghai. But this time, he was no longer so afraid of making the wrong choice. When he went back inside, Grandfather was still up, reading with his glasses on. Grandfather looked up and asked, "Have you made up your mind?" Haoran smiled. "Not yet. But whichever road I take, who knows how things will turn out?" Grandfather smiled too. 30